
SESSION 2A

WE NEED REPENTANCE

FOR FELLOWSHIP

When we do something wrong, we want to hide: hide it, hide the truth, and hide ourselves. It started way back in the Garden of Eden.



GENESIS 3:8-10 (ESV)

⁸ And they heard the sound of the LORD God walking in the garden in the cool of the day, and the man and his wife hid themselves from the presence of the LORD God among the trees of the garden. ⁹ But the LORD God called to the man and said to him, “Where are you?” ¹⁰ And he said, “I heard the sound of you in the garden, and I was afraid, because I was naked, and I hid myself.”

God’s response to naked, ashamed Adam is to seek him out. “Where are you?” he asks. This has ever been God’s question to man: where are you? Let’s talk this through. What have you done, and what are you becoming? God wants to engage with us, and draw us out of the miry pit we often dig for ourselves.



ISAIAH 1:18 (ESV)

¹⁸ “Come now, let us reason together, says the LORD:
though your sins are like scarlet,
they shall be as white as snow;
though they are red like crimson,
they shall become like wool.

From Genesis, through the Prophets, and into the New Testament, God’s invitation has always been the same: “Let’s talk.”

According to 1 John 1:1-10, the goal is fellowship. We were meant for a close walk with God, as Father and child. God wants nothing to weaken our relational connection with him. It’s vital for us that we walk in openness and love with him, without hiding or fear.



1 JOHN 1:1-10 (ESV)

¹ That which was from the beginning, which we have heard, which we have seen with our eyes, which we looked upon and have touched with our hands, concerning the word of life— ² the life was made manifest, and we have seen it, and testify to it and proclaim to you the eternal life, which was with the Father and was made manifest to us— ³ that which we have seen and heard we proclaim also to you, so that you too may have fellowship with us; and indeed our fellowship is with the Father and with his Son Jesus Christ. ⁴ And we are writing these things so that our joy may be complete.

⁵ This is the message we have heard from him and proclaim to you, that God is light, and in him is no darkness at all. ⁶ If we say we have fellowship with him while we walk in darkness, we lie and do not practice the truth. ⁷ But if we walk in the light, as he is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus his Son cleanses us from all sin. ⁸ If we say we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us. ⁹ If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness. ¹⁰ If we say we have not sinned, we make him a liar, and his word is not in us.

God's wish is for fellowship. There is joy in this. The problem is that we hide. We prefer the darkness because it provides cover for our sins.

This is pretty good news.

In fact, the first words of Jesus' public ministry recorded in the gospels is, "Repent and believe the good news." What good news? The good news is that the holy God is waiting to forgive you if you'd stop hiding and denying your sins, and step out into truth/light and "confess our sins."

That IS good news! That's the gospel!



MARK 1:14–15 (ESV)

¹⁴Now after John was arrested, Jesus came into Galilee, proclaiming the gospel of God, ¹⁵and saying, "The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel."

What is involved in the process of someone coming out to the light?

According to this passage, what is promised when we do come out to the light?

VIEW OF REPENTANCE

What is your view of repentance?

What makes repentance difficult?

REPENTANCE LEADS TO FELLOWSHIP

Repentance is something that all of us who call ourselves Christians are familiar with, for we could not have received salvation without having gone through it. Not only are we converted through repentance, but we also live our Christian lives daily through repentance.

Some of the words/phrases you may have written may be:

U-turn
Bittersweet
Sorrowful
Difficult
Painful
Sad
Grieved
What I needed to go through in order to become a Christian

But perhaps maybe words like the following come to your mind when you think of repentance:

Dreadful
Burdensome
Self-flagellating
Traumatizing

If repentance is the avenue to fellowship, it follows that without it we would no longer have fellowship with God. (Unless of course, we never sin—which, according to 1 John 1:8-10 just doesn't happen.) For Christians, our position as God's forgiven child, justified and righteous before God, is secure for all eternity. A relationship is forever. I am forever my wife's husband, though on some days I may be a bad or irritating one.

Our sins past, present, and future have all been paid by Jesus, and when we placed our trust in his finished work, God declared us pardoned and righteous. Thus our sins do not threaten our standing with God. As the saying goes, "There is nothing you can do to make God love you more; and there is nothing you can do to make God love you less." All has been completed on the cross by Jesus, and granted to us as a gift. This is what is so amazing about grace.

Although our position is secure through Christ, our sins affect our fellowship with God. Like Adam in hiding, our sins cause us to fear God, and doubt our standing with him. Pride may also flare up, and we may want to deny that we have sinned. All this starts to cool our affection toward God, and weaken our bond with him.

Take the following illustration. Let's say that I warn my ten-year-old son that he should not play with his baseball inside the house, and especially not in the living room where I have on display an expensive vase from the Ming dynasty. But he does, and ends up breaking the vase in several pieces. He nervously super-glues the pieces together, and places the vase back on its stand. I come home, and do not receive my usual welcome from my son. Instead, he's in his room.

Let's see if we can finish this illustration along several different lines of possibilities:

- My son seems edgy at dinner. He seems extra nervous when I ask him about his baseball team. He seems to monitor my every move, and tries to cut me off when I head toward the living room after dinner. I never discover that the vase was broken ... but my son seems increasingly distant from me. He seems to not enjoy my presence like he used to. **What is happening?**
- My son is in his room doing extra amounts of homework, memorizing vocabulary words, and doing other such things that I've asked him to do but that he had been putting off. **Why would he do this? What must be his reasoning, and what is wrong with that line of thinking?**

- My son is packing a few of his belongings and climbing out the window. He has left me a note saying that he is sorry, and that he is no longer worthy to be my son, so he's leaving. **Again, what is the reasoning, and what is wrong with it?**
- My son has put on angry heavy-metal music with lyrics like, "rebel against the Man," and other anti-authority and anarchist sentiments. **What's going on?**

Here's how the rest of the illustration usually goes.

I discover the clumsily glued vase and figure out what happened. I see the nervousness of my son, who has decided to (in the words of 1 John 1) "claim he has not sinned" and is choosing to "walk in darkness," while claiming to have fellowship with his dad. It actually grieves me that he chose to hide his sin, and is now hiding from me because he broke the vase. I want him to approach me and confess, but he doesn't. Over dinner, I casually mention his baseball team and the game coming up. He seems nervous about this. I say, "Hey, you want to go into the living room, and we can have a ball ... talking about baseball ... next to that vase?" Unable to keep up the tension, my son bursts into tears, confessing everything. I give him a big hug, and tell him it's OK, and I ask him not to hide it when he messes up in the future, that he can always count on me to forgive him, and help him through things. And we talk about why he chose to throw around the baseball inside the house in the first place. Did he forget? Did he think, "Aw, it'll be alright, I won't break anything?" We have a conversation that will hopefully build his character. Afterwards, we feel closer. The bonds of our fellowship seem to have grown stronger, and my son seems to have grown through this.

In light of the above illustration and the 1 John 1 passage, what are some false views of God or twisted thoughts that cause you to dread repentance?

SESSION 2A QUIZ

Although our position is secure through Christ, our sins affect our _____ with God.

Which answer best summarizes Session 2A? _____ is the avenue to _____ with God.

- a) Repentance, fellowship
- b) Fellowship, relationship
- c) Confession, repentance
- d) Good works, peace